Keep window on top of taskbar on Windows 11

Asked 6 months ago Modified 6 months ago Viewed 188 times

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I found that on windows 11, even if I created windows with `WS_EX_TOPMOST` style, the window still get covered by taskbar if you click anywhere on the taskbar. The **only exception** to this is task manager. How does it achieve it?

I want a feature to draw stuff on the taskbar, or at least mimic that behavior using a transparent window. I think there used to be 2 ways to achieve that:

1. Get DC of taskbar and draw (which no longer work on Windows11)
2. Create a transparent window and keep it on top of taskbar (issues with how to keep it topmost)

I kind of get stuck now. Any help is appreciated.

UPDATE: I just noticed that the taskbar window, shown as `DesktopWindowXamlSource` in *Spy++* does not have the `WS_EX_TOPMOST` style set. I guess it's possible to cover it for some ways?

```
#ifndef UNICODE
#define UNICODE
#endif

#include <windows.h>
#include <iostream>

LRESULT CALLBACK WindowProc(HWND hwnd, UINT uMsg, WPARAM wParam, LPARAM lParam);

int WINAPI wWinMain(HINSTANCE hInstance, HINSTANCE hPrevInstance, PWSTR pCmdLine,
int nCmdShow)
{
    // Register the window class.
    const wchar_t CLASS_NAME[] = L"Sample Window Class";

    WNDCLASS wc = { };

    wc.lpfnWndProc = WindowProc;
    wc.hInstance = hInstance;
    wc.lpszClassName = CLASS_NAME;

    RegisterClass(&wc);

    // Create the window.

    HWND hwnd = CreateWindowEx(
        WS_EX_TOPMOST,                  // Optional window styles.
        CLASS_NAME,                     // Window class
        L"Learn to Program Windows",    // Window text
```

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```
            NULL,       // Parent window
            NULL,       // Menu
            hInstance,  // Instance handle
            NULL        // Additional application data
        );

        if (hwnd == NULL)
        {
            return 0;
        }
        ShowWindow(hwnd, nCmdShow);
        // Run the message loop.

        MSG msg = { };
        while (GetMessage(&msg, NULL, 0, 0) > 0)
        {
            TranslateMessage(&msg);
            DispatchMessage(&msg);
        }
    }

    LRESULT CALLBACK WindowProc(HWND hwnd, UINT uMsg, WPARAM wParam, LPARAM lParam)
    {
        switch (uMsg)
        {
            case WM_DESTROY:
                PostQuitMessage(0);
                return 0;

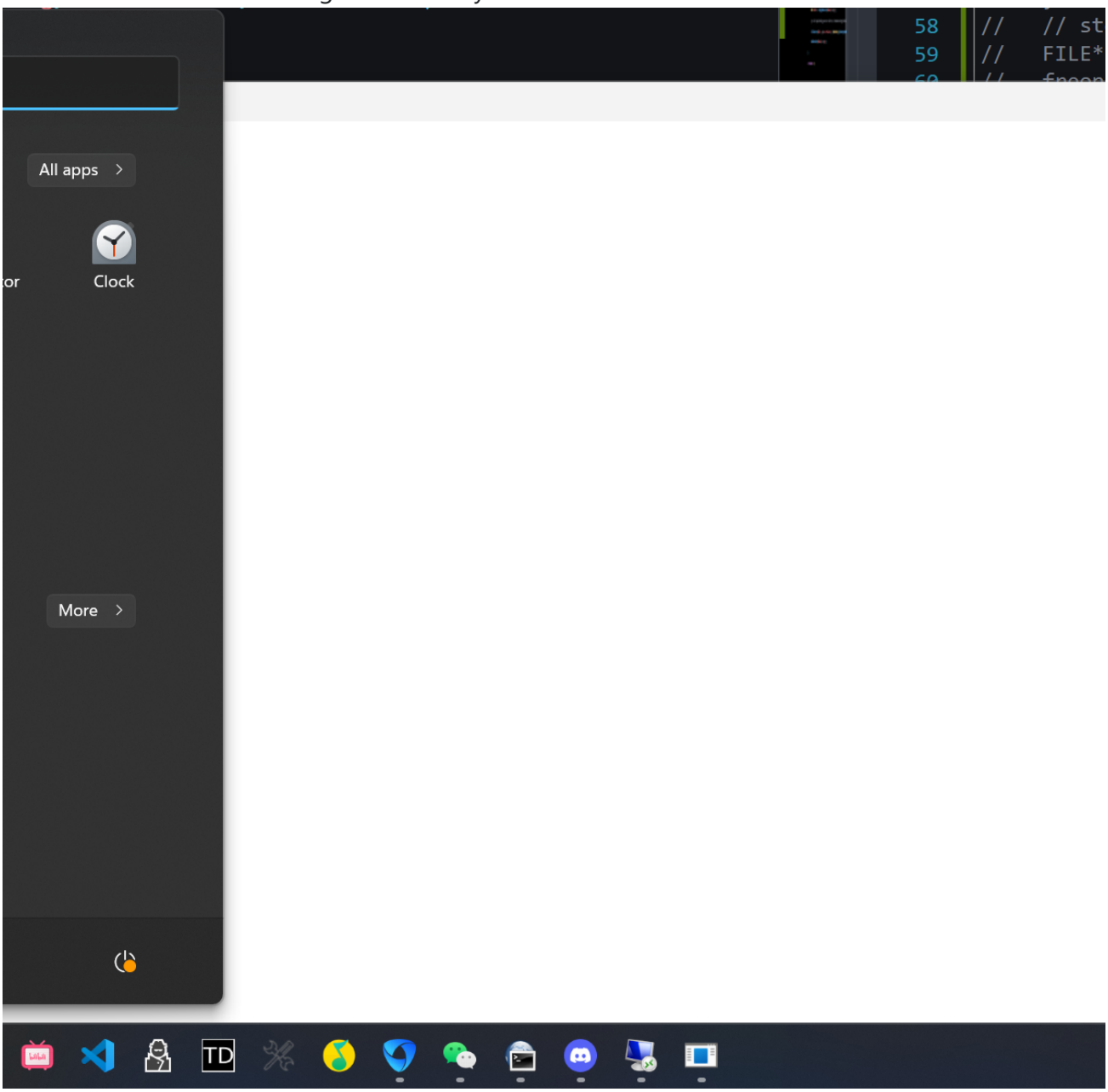
            case WM_PAINT:
            {
                PAINTSTRUCT ps;
                HDC hdc = BeginPaint(hwnd, &ps);
                // All painting occurs here, between BeginPaint and EndPaint.
                FillRect(hdc, &ps.rcPaint, (HBRUSH)(COLOR_WINDOW + 1));
                EndPaint(hwnd, &ps);
            }
            return 0;

        }
        return DefWindowProc(hwnd, uMsg, wParam, lParam);
    }
```

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And this is how the window get covered by taskbar when I click start.



winapi

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asked Apr 6 at 13:14



sz ppeter
1,644 1 6 19

3 "How does it achieve it?" It is part of the system, your code is not. – David Heffernan Apr 6 at 16:00

2 MS reasonably doesn't really want you to do this... because malware authors could use it to block access to things. – Mgetz Apr 6 at 17:20

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Could you please show a minimal, reproducible sample without private information? What do you mean keep window on top of taskbar? Whether you want the window to cover the taskbar? – Jeaninez - MSFT Apr 7 at 7:07

@Jeaninez-MSFT added – sz ppeter Apr 7 at 12:43

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